How we plan the quarter

Work types, sizing, commitments, and trust. A reference for our quarterly planning week.



Why we are here this week

What this week produces

A realistic quarterly plan that teams believe in and can execute.

What it is not

A debate about whether we picked the right priorities.

Ground rules

- Feedback on whether these are the right items is welcome, but it only applies to *future* quarterly plans.
- This quarter's list is the best prioritization based on what we know right now.
- This week we scope, size, and commit.

If this is our first time

- Some prep that normally happens before planning is not done yet.
- Expect a messier first pass.
- The goal is a plan and a repeatable habit, not a perfect plan.

The week at a glance

Four half-day sessions, with gaps between them to research, think, and resolve dependencies.

	SESSION	WHAT HAPPENS	OUTPUT
1	**Strategy and candidates** Leads: Product manager	Goal progress, last quarter's commitments, candidates in one ranked list. Questions only.	Shared context, sizing assignments
2	**Sizing** Leads: Scrum master	Size the pieces, then the Deliverables. Wide disagreement gets a second round.	Sized items, dependencies, confidence
3	**Technical maintenance and capacity** Leads: Technical architect, scrum master	List the maintenance work. Count the days. Draw the cut-off line. Map slices to sprints.	What fits, and what doesn't
4	**Commitment** Leads: Product manager	Vote of confidence. Each person commits out loud. Agree the stakeholder message.	Committed plan, stakeholder message

Three work types, plus organization business

Strategic

Work that advances our roadmap goals and creates new value for users. Discovery and delivery.

Default 50%

Technical maintenance

Work that keeps current services running, healthy and secure, and improves our team's ability to deliver value.

Default 25%

Small requests

Work requested by people outside our team, sent to the small request board by triage.

Default 25%

Organization business

Department meetings, organizational meetings, trainings, and administrative tasks. Not a work type.

Off the top

Every piece of work belongs to one type. Organization business comes off the top before we count the days we have for hands-on work.

Examples by type

Strategic

- New features for roadmap goals
- Validating roadmap assumptions
- UX solutions for roadmap services
- Content frameworks for new services

Technical maintenance

- Security updates and maintenance
- Bug fixes
- Tool migrations for cost
- Continuous discovery setup
- Design system upkeep
- Analytics and measurement setup

Small requests

- Quick usability reviews
- Accessibility updates
- CMS fixes and editor support
- Data requests from leadership

Organization business

- Department all-hands
- Mandatory training
- Timesheets and admin
- Affinity groups

Which type is it?

Ask in order. Stop at the first yes.

1	Does it advance a roadmap goal?	**Strategic**
2	Does it keep services running, healthy and secure, or help our team work better?	**Technical maintenance**
3	Did someone outside our team ask for it, and triage sent it to the small request board?	**Small requests**
4	Is it department or organization business, outside our service delivery?	**Off the top**

When maintenance work directly enables a roadmap item, pick one type for it and move on.

Meetings and training

Technical maintenance

- Sprint planning and retrospectives
- Standups and team coordination
- Quarterly planning
- Design reviews and technical discussions
- Process improvement meetings
- Training the team chooses (like agile)

Organization business

- Department all-hands
- Organization-wide meetings
- Required cross-department meetings
- Mandatory HR training
- Budget meetings where we only participate

Quick test: Is it about how our team works together or delivers services? Technical maintenance. Is it department or organization business? Off the top. For training, who decided?

How we split our time

The split is set each quarter. Start from 50/25/25 and adjust to the work at hand.



Adjust for the quarter

A fixed launch date may call for more Strategic. A system near end of life may call for more Technical maintenance. Write the split and the reason down.

Some teams differ for longer

A team mostly doing discovery might run 70/15/15. A team that mostly runs existing services might run 20/50/30.

Watch for patterns

If a team keeps overriding the default the same way, that is a signal. Change its default and say why.

Equal importance doesn't mean equal time. Each type gets protected time, so none of them quietly eats the others.

Capacity math

Work it out per person, before anything gets cut.

1

Start with the quarter

13 weeks: 65 weekdays, six two-week sprints plus a spare week.

2

Take off time away

Holidays, planned vacation, and big events the team must support.

3

Take off organization business

All-hands meetings, mandatory training, timesheets.

4

Split what is left

By this quarter's work types. Strategic days divided by 10 gives Strategic sprints.

At 50% Strategic, each person has about **3 Strategic sprints** in a quarter (about 3.5 at 60%). That number is what the fit check uses.

A plan built on 65 days the team doesn't have is a promise already broken.

Size the effort, not the calendar

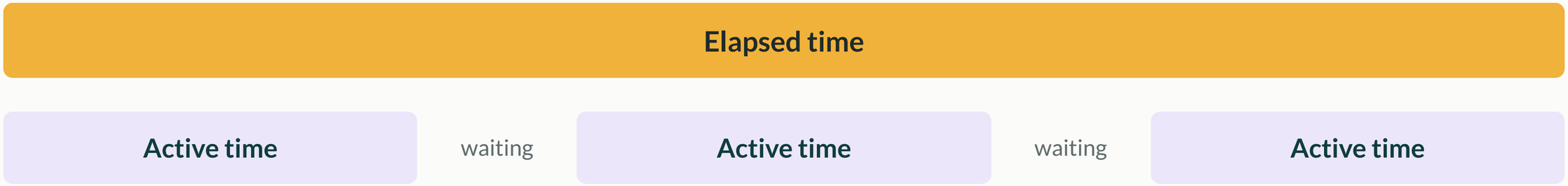
ELAPSED TIME

How much time will elapse between us starting and us finishing?

vs

ACTIVE TIME

How much active time will I actually spend working on this?



The T-shirt size is the lavender blocks. Waiting, approvals, and scheduling go on the calendar as dates and dependencies.

Two examples

Active time: what we size Elapsed time: what we don't

Getting staff feedback

Send the email	**5 min**
Gap before the session	**2 weeks**
Hold the session	**1 hr**

T-shirt size: 1 hr 5 min, not 2 weeks

Google Translate API integration

Write the API integration	**4 hrs**
Test and debug	**2 hrs**
Google's API responds	**200 ms**

T-shirt size: about 6 hours

What counts toward the size

Counts: active time

- Hands-on building, design, research
- Problem-solving and debugging
- Testing and quality assurance
- Documentation and deployment
- Direct work with teammates

Doesn't count: elapsed time

- Approvals and sign-offs
- Scheduling delays
- Waiting on vendors or other teams
- Status meetings and reporting
- Interruptions and context switching

Sizing asks how hard it is to build. Capacity planning asks how much building time we have. Waiting belongs on the calendar.

T-shirt sizes, in sprints of focused work

XS	S	M	L	XL
A few hours	One sprint or less	About 2 sprints	3-4 sprints	5 sprints or more

Why an XL splits

A quarter has 6 sprints, and each person has about 3 for Strategic work. An XL can't finish inside one quarter, so it's a Solution, not a Deliverable. Slice it. An L fits, but only just, so check its dependencies hardest.

Why sprints

Stakeholders can read sprints, so T-shirt sizes go on the roadmap. Story points are optional inside the team, for stories, not for roadmap items.

The cut-off line

Line up the ranked list. Add the sizes. Draw the line where capacity runs out.

1	Candidate 1	**M**	Running total: 2
2	Candidate 2	**S**	Running total: 3
3	Candidate 3	**L**	Running total: 6.5

Cut-off line: capacity is 8 Strategic sprints

4	Candidate 4	**M**	Running total: 8.5
5	Candidate 5	**S**	Running total: 9.5

The rule

Everything below the line is out of this quarter. The product manager can swap items across the line, but can't move the line.

The fit check

For each person or pair, add up the sizes they own and compare with their Strategic sprints. Anyone over budget means something gets cut.

Saying out loud what didn't make it is what makes the rest believable.

Vote of confidence

Before anyone commits, everyone shows a score from 1 to 5 at the same moment.



Anyone at 1 or 2 says why

Same moment, so nobody anchors on the loudest voice.

Fix the plan, not the person

Cut scope or change the plan until everyone is at 3 or above.

Then commit out loud

Each person says they commit to the plan.

A low vote is information, not dissent. Quiet members often have the best risk insight.

Making a commitment

At the end of this week, you'll verbally commit to the plan.

A commitment is a promise to try, not a guarantee.

What it means

With focus, you believe you can do your part, without working extra hours.

What it doesn't mean

You won't be in trouble. Try your best within your time and flag risks early.

What we expect

Some misses are assumed. The system is meant to push us in positive ways.

Commitments lock on the first day of the quarter. Status is updated each sprint review: Committed, On track, Off track, or Done.

The trust this asks for

We're asking you to trust that...

- this system will work, even if it takes time
- the product manager is making the right strategic calls
- working this way gets our community more value
- sizing honestly means no sandbagging, from anyone
- you won't get in trouble, and failure is celebrated
- we all assume positive intent with one another

Trust is earned, and it can also be asked for. Today, we're asking.

Productive tension

Be ambitious with goals	↔	Be realistic about capacity
Plan with a roadmap	↔	Adapt when plans change
Commit to the work	↔	Say early when you can't deliver
Focus on user outcomes	↔	Navigate stakeholder needs
Be accountable for outcomes	↔	Experiment, and let some fail

These tensions are intentional. The framework gives us structure; the work happens in the messy middle, and **trust is what lets us live there together.**

This is a lot

Huge cognitive overload

If you remember 10% or understand 10%, that's pretty good!

Repetition and practice are how we get to 100%.

